

CHAPTER 1

Unearthing the Need for Genius and Joy

"The world is a fine place and worth fighting for."

—ERNEST HEMINGWAY

LAYERED PLAYLIST

Songs that inspire me about genius and joy. Play them as you read this chapter.

"I Wish I Knew How It Would Feel to Be Free,"
Nina Simone

"Alabama,"
John Coltrane

"What's Going On,"
Marvin Gaye

"Let Up," Abbey Lincoln

"State of the World,"
Janet Jackson

"Gimme Mine,"
Tall Black Guy
featuring 80s Babies

"Conversation Peace,"
Stevie Wonder

"If I Ruled the World (Imagine That)," Nas
featuring Lauryn Hill

"I Shall Be Released,"
Nina Simone

"Blowin' in the Wind,"
Bob Dylan



Oppression

by Langston Hughes

Now dreams
Are not available
To the dreamers,
Nor songs
To the singers.

In some lands
Dark night
And cold steel
Prevail—

But the dream
Will come back,
And the song
Break
Its jail.

Freedom

by Langston Hughes

Freedom will not come
Today, this year
Nor ever
Through compromise and fear.

I have as much right
As the other fellow has
To stand
On my two feet
And own the land.

I tire so of hearing people say,
Let things take their course.
Tomorrow is another day.
I do not need my freedom when I'm dead.
I cannot live on tomorrow's bread.

Freedom
Is a strong seed
Planted
In a great need.
I live here, too.
I want my freedom
Just as you.

Unearthing Thought

- 1 What type of PreK–12 education have you experienced? Whose cultures, stories, and histories were taught and represented? Whose were not? What type of learning did you experience or not experience?
- 2 What were problems from your own education? Do you still see those problems in schools today?
- 3 What examples of genius from your childhood helped you to learn and experience joy? Do you still see those examples in schools today?
- 4 If you could offer a metaphor for the educational system, what would it be and why?
- 5 What theories and models prepared you to be a teacher or leader? Are there theories and models that you still need? What are they?
- 6 Equity, justice, and culturally responsive practices have been around throughout history but have never been mandated in schools. Why do you think that is?
- 7 What is needed for equity, justice, and culturally responsive practices to be adopted and mandated in policy?
- 8 What are your thoughts when analyzing and critiquing these five parts of the system: 1) learning standards; 2) curriculum; 3) assessment/standardized tests; 4) teacher and leader evaluations; and 5) teacher education programs? How do those parts capture, express, evaluate, and build genius and joy? How is there a lack of culturally and historically responsive education?
- 9 What historical triumphs have shaped the system?
- 10 Given your state, district, and board policies, what kind of advocacy is needed to advance the system?

But Where Shall I Begin?

In her biographical account, *My Name Is Phillis Wheatley: A Story of Slavery and Freedom* (2009), activist-poet-scholar Afua Cooper writes in the voice of our beloved Sister Phillis Wheatley. She questions her starting point in narrating the life and times of Wheatley: “But where shall I begin? With my despair or with my triumph? Do I start with my life as an African child? Or my sufferings on the slave ship? Shall I begin with describing the first time I wrote a complete poem and tell of the sweet joy that flowed through my body? No. I shall begin with what I see shimmering in front of me.”

Wheatley was an activist, poet, and writer who spent her life working toward a better humanity for Black people and, consequently, for everyone. She wrote about the life and times of the day, about humanity, and about joy. She wrote to (re) imagine a world absent of hurt, pain, harm, and injustice. Wheatley established a tradition of writing about the earth and its need for watering, in her poem, *On Imagination* (1773):

Though Winter frowns to Fancy’s raptur’d eyes
The fields may flourish, and gay scenes arise;
The frozen deeps may break their iron bands,
And bid their waters murmur o’er the sands.
Fair Flora may resume her fragrant reign,
And with her flow’ry riches deck the plain;
Sylvanus may diffuse his honours round,
And all the forest may with leaves be crown’d
Show’rs may descend, and dews their gems disclose,
And nectar sparkle on the blooming rose.



Phillis Wheatley

In this glorious piece of writing, Wheatley allows us to visualize a world without enslavement or racism—and their harmful lingering effects. She (re)imagined a better, emancipated world, free of oppression, by detailing flourishing and fragrant landscapes blooming. It comes as no surprise why Cooper chose to study the life and writings of Wheatley. She opens her book by asking an important question: *Where should the story begin?*

Should the story begin with the despair and pain such as the suffering on the slave ship? Or shall her story begin with triumph and beauty, such as detailing her life as an African child where she was seen, heard, and loved? Cooper also ponders the thought of opening with “sweet joy” embodying the spirit of Wheatley’s poetry writing.

I have been asking myself the same question as I open this book. Where should I begin the story of education—of children and of educators? Do I begin with despair, addressing the historic and oppressive structures that have created low achievement, low joy, low pay, and teachers leaving the field? Should I begin with the triumphs by addressing the beautiful genius that educators and children bring each day to schools? Or perhaps with joy? My inquiry was not a simple one, but it grabbed my attention because all three—despair, triumph, and joy—tell the truthful and complete narrative of education.

Despair is the result of structures and policies that have not always served children and teachers well. It is felt by teachers when they are intellectually trapped in curriculum that promotes low-level skills and contains texts that stifle their creativity. Much is also true of youth. Sometimes I wonder why we maintain such basic educational standards and models of mediocracy, given our brilliant history of people of color and other abolitionists, and the examples they provide. While some educators believe they are shifting the landscape, I wonder if their work is truly transformative. As a literacy teacher and scholar, I have witnessed new terms and titles for literacy programs, year after year. New terms and titles, however, do not mean different core approaches to literacies. Nor do they truly speak to transformation.

I also struggle with the fact that harmful structures of the past are still in place today, failing many children and teachers of color, especially Indigenous and Black children and teachers. Even districts with large percentages of children and teachers of color adopt models, evaluations, and frameworks that are not written by or designed for people of color. Rather, they are written by organizations, companies, and groups that don't reflect the identities and lives of the people for whom the materials are created.

Traditionally, schools share so-called equity data that narrates what children cannot do instead of what they can do. That data then becomes a prominent “story” of the school community. School leaders have even used data to create harmful programs and practices for students.

→ *Defining Equity*

Many approaches and programs in schools certainly do not offer students of color an opportunity for true or full equity. Equity has been mis-defined as simply providing rigor or access to all. But it is much more than that. Equity is teaching and learning that is centered on justice, liberation, truth, and freedom, and is free of bias and favoritism. You cannot talk about true justice, liberation, truth, and freedom without talking about anti-racism. Equity is not just about adding a multicultural book to the classroom library or providing access to something educationally good or sound. Doing that does not ensure that children will learn about their identities and histories, nor the liberation of themselves and others. Multicultural books can still be used to teach in incomplete and deficit ways. If a school has skills-only curriculum, and it reports only data from one skills-only standardized assessment, it isn't fully equitable. A school that is truly equitable embraces fairness and inclusion, and it responds to students' individual needs, providing structures, systems, and practices that enable all students to reach their highest potential for personal and academic success. Equity as access only, without addressing structural oppression/racism, isn't equity in its fullness. Schools that report only on test scores and gaps tell a false story rather than the truth of what led to those scores and gaps.

Given that, it is also fair to say that, too often, we do not tell stories of triumph, such as the stories of teachers who show up every day, striving for a holistic and complete education for their students, regardless of the limitations of standards, curriculum, or society. We also do not tell the stories of triumphs of children who are victorious despite being immersed in a system that is not designed to embrace their histories, identities, literacies, or liberation.

We certainly hardly ever begin the story with joy—joy of children, teachers, or leaders. During the COVID-19 pandemic, many individuals and organizations promoted the language of “learning loss.” I deeply believe that there has been learning loss since the inception of public schools in the United States, given what was present and what was not. During the pandemic, learning loss did not feel new for children or teachers of color because of the historically countless missed opportunities to teach children who they are and whose they are. Companies yet again profited from sensationalized language. Yet no one really spoke of “joy loss.” No one spoke of how joy is at the center of how we move in the world of education and why we return to school each day. In this chapter's opening excerpt about Phillis Wheatley, Cooper adds, *I shall begin [the story] with what I see shimmering in front of me.* I asked myself, what is shimmering in front of us?

I answered: Genius and joy. The genius and joy of our children and educators.

Equity is teaching and learning that is centered on justice, liberation, truth, and freedom.

The story of schools rarely starts with genius and joy, and the ways liberatory educators have disrupted harmful learning. Joy is the beauty of learning that traditional state testing does not capture. Regardless of painful and misaligned educational practices, past and present, the genius and joy of our children still shimmer. We must (re)member the past and leaders such as Phillis Wheatley who give us examples of shimmering genius and joy.

A Brief History of Genius, Justice, and Joy

There are so many examples of genius, justice, and joy through history, which provide a great opportunity to learn from communities of color. Because I offer only a few in this section, I encourage you to seek more moments of and movements in genius, justice, and joy throughout history and today.

Beginning from ancient times of Timbuktu, Mali (West Africa), Black people carried gleaming genius.

The people of Timbuktu viewed literacy and books as treasures and road maps to discovering cultures and the global universe—and they protected, sustained, and elevated them. They made more wealth from the sale of books and manuscripts than from any other product (Saad, 2010). This is special, and a beautiful goal for today. Can you imagine if our nation's wealth came primarily from the sale of books? Their books were in demand and beautifully made from fine paper and ink. This is genius and joy. Their topics included Islam, mathematics, and science (Singleton, 2004). Books provided joy, personal fulfillment, and a pathway to freedom. When colonizers tried to seize their books—their sources of knowledge—for control and profit, the people of Timbuktu hid and protected them. That is genius. The lessons from this land and its people show how we must center genius, libraries, and diverse texts, and protect truth in knowledge.

In examples of shimmering genius and joy across the world, I am reminded of a time during 1800s enslavement, one of the most oppressive times in society, when the ancestors created genius through literacy/education. Literacy/education was the centering of the practices and livelihoods of African people. They always created a space when one did not exist. For example, to communicate routes to freedom, we would braid maps into young women and girls' hair. As such, hair braiding is not just beautiful and creative, but also connected to justice and liberation. Speaking to that, and to the genius of enslaved Africans, Ziomara



Books made by the people of Timbuktu



Asprilla García explained in a *Washington Post* article by DeNeen Brown that women would create “departes,” thick, tight braids, with a bun at the top of their heads to send a message that they wanted to escape. “The curved braids would represent the roads they would use” (2011).

This history was not largely documented in print to protect Black people and enable them to continue to use hair braiding as a way to freedom.



Hair braiding to express higher levels of meaning and thinking also signified semiotics, mathematics, and geography before they became official disciplines of study in today's PreK–12 classrooms. Here lies a history embedded with identity, skills, intellect, criticality, and joy. The practice of literacies, geography, and STEM extended in reading the world through pathways, such as the Underground Railroad and Sister Harriet Tubman's reading of the night sky—the celestial gourd and the North Star, something natural and beautiful, as a map toward freedom (Dunbar, 2019). The ancestors read the earth as text and navigated themselves and others to freedom.

The ancestors also used what computer scientists now call *coding* and *algorithms* to send messages leading to freedom. They did that through music and lyrics. Songs contained coded messages. They were codified to signal protest and escape. It has been known that songs, such as "I Got My Ticket" and "Go Down Moses," were used as codes for fleeing to the North for safety. When the ancestors heard them sung, they knew they signified something prominent related to liberation. My youngest brother has a degree in computer science but, sadly, he was not offered a comprehensive history course that included this example. This would have been a great way to intro the history of coding and using codes for sending messages.

(top) Hair braiding was used to communicate routes to freedom.
(bottom) Songs were codified to signal protest and escape.

Go down, Moses

(Let my people go!)

Exodus VIII

Negro Spiritual
Arranged by
H. T. BURLEIGH

Lento

Voice

Piano

When

Is - rael was in E - gypt's lan' Let my people go. Op -

preas'do hard they could not stand, Let my people go.

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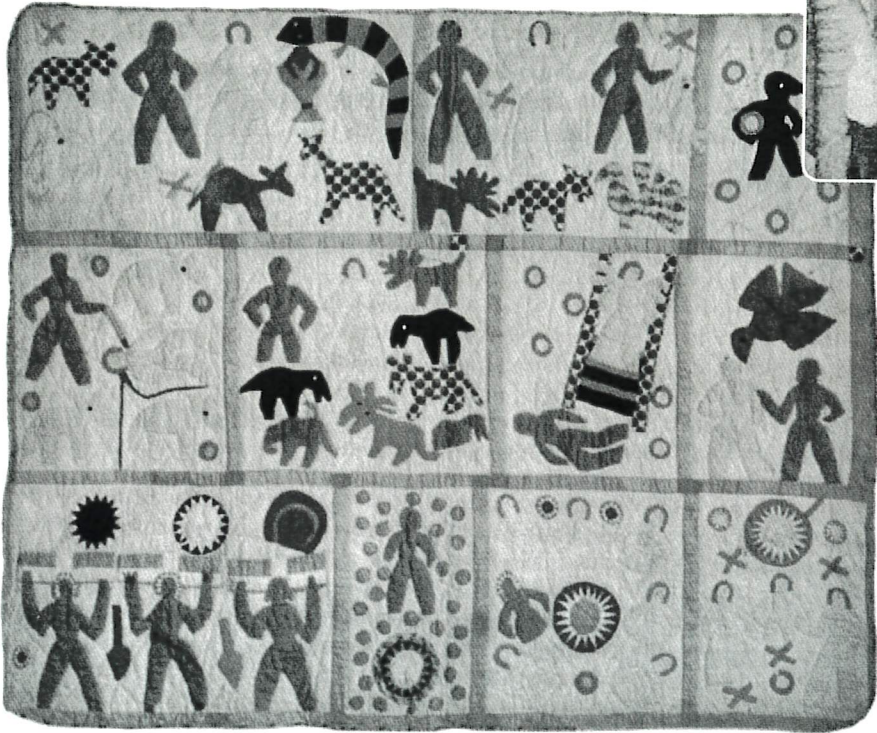
This is yet another example of the genius of the times and a form of genius that we don't honor enough in schools.

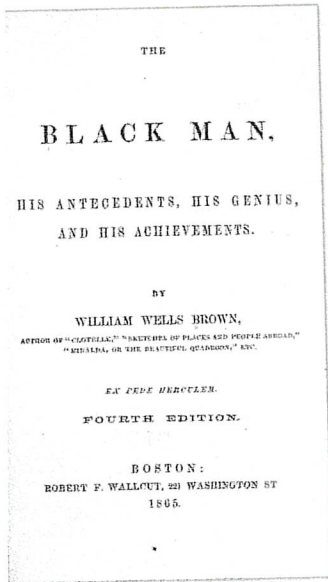
The ancestors also embodied the gift of multiple literacies, such as Harriet Powers, who told stories of justice, joy, and truth in the literacy practice of quilting; not just speaking and writing. Too often, education privileges certain literacies. But children today have genius and, with it, multiple ways of showing meaning, just as they did in the past. Even when we ask children to take school, district, and state assessments, we do not ask them to showcase multiple literacies.

Genius was extended through creative, innovative, and expressive language practices, such as those of the Tutnese and Gullah Geechee people. Developed in the 18th century, Gullah is a creole language spoken by descendants of Africans in certain regions of South Carolina and Georgia (Geraty, 1997). It is derived from African languages, but mixed with forms of English—the language that was forced upon Africans to colonize them. Similarly, genius ancestors from Southern



Harriet Powers told stories of justice, joy, and truth in the literacy practice of quilting.





regions also developed special and unique sounds and words that enabled them to communicate with one another. They called this language Tutnese or Tut language (McIlwain, 1995). Language devices were developed in secret because learning to read and write was forbidden. To create and develop new language is innovative and certainly genius. Sadly, though, these histories are not taught in most schools. We should begin to think about their implications for English language arts and communication courses today.

In addition, the ancestors created and used language to write about our genius and joy, and even used the term *genius* in the titles of books. See example to the left.

They created model learning spaces such as hush harbors, literary societies, and anti-slavery and other abolitionist organizations—all examples of genius from the nineteenth century, and the genius and joy carried into the next two centuries, as well as with the emergence of African-centered schools, Freedom Schools of the

1960s, Kitchen Table Talks, hip-hop, and other creative and intellectual modes of education. Through it all, we retained joy, even when striving for justice.

In the following example from the February 11, 1837, issue of the *Weekly Advocate* newspaper, one of the first African American publications, we see the power of learning:

READING. He that would be an intelligent person must be a reading person. By reading you may visit all countries, converse with the wise, good, and great, who have lived in any age or country, imbibe their very feelings and sentiments, and view every thing elegant in architecture, sculpture, and painting. By reading you may ascend to those remote regions where other spheres encircle other suns, where other stars illumine a new expanse of skies, and enkindle the most sublime emotions that can animate the human soul.

Without being a reading person, your information must be limited, and of a local nature.

Here, literacy (reading) and education were connected to genius, intelligence, and joy. We find beautiful language here of what education offers. It offers the beauty and ascensions in the world with goals of “enkindling sublime emotions that can animate the human soul.” This is joy.

Rather than opening stories with the historic genius of children, too many of us instead use deficit terms to describe them—labels that demean them (e.g., non-white, minority, disadvantaged) and unjustly categorize them (e.g., struggling, unmotivated, nonreaders, low achievers). I have stopped using the term “minorities” because even when people of color are in the majority, they are still referred to as “the minority.” I don’t like including the word *minor* to refer to any group of people. Such terms are debilitating, potentially causing mental injury to youth as they internalize those terms and, as such, see themselves as “less than.” To combat this, we must first study histories, systems, and structures of education that have led us to where we are today and their lingering effects. From there, we move to ways to implement healthier models and strategies for students.

The Earth Is in Need of Water

In the last 20 years, I have had opportunities to work across communities in leadership, teaching, and advisory positions, bearing witness to the beauty and essence of so many people striving for a better education for children. It became clear that in their striving, educators and community members have been working in a parched system designed to exclude children of color and other children who have been marginalized—and to exclude their genius and joy. In the introduction to this book, I asked a pivotal question: *How can we water the earth that systemic racism and oppression have made dry?* To understand joy and the need for joy, we must first study the earth and the systems of education that have inhibited and erased it from schools and classrooms—from students and educators.

Throughout my career, I have recognized the need for culturally responsive teaching and learning, but the educational system itself has been in great conflict with it and absent of it. Even when people of color and conscious leaders are on school boards, and are superintendents and principals, we still see few CRE/CHRE (culturally responsive education/culturally and historically responsive education) mandates. Even though we have research and scholarship on CRE/CHRE stemming from the 19th century, we still don’t observe its theories, models, and practices reflected in school policies. In fact, CRE/CHRE feels like an add-on—or option for schools to enact. Many schools add it to professional

development, yet leave their curriculum, evaluations, learning standards, and testing norms unchanged. Teachers are then left to wonder how to implement what a professional development provider recommended when they are going to be evaluated on opposite/standardized practices.

For example, if we take the Danielson Framework for teaching, which many districts use for teacher evaluation, we would not observe any explicit CRE/CHRE language other than academic skills. In school districts, we continue to use frameworks that were not written by or for Black educators or children, nor other people of color.

A Brief History of Erasure of Genius, Justice, and Joy

That absence of representation isn't coincidental.

A Measuring Rod...

In the late 1800s, Mildred Lewis Rutherford authored a book that was published and supported by the United Daughters of the Confederacy (UDC): *A Measuring Rod to Test Text Books, and Reference Books in Schools, Colleges and Libraries* (1920). It was designed to inform educators and educational publishers about what should and shouldn't be included in teaching and learning in K-12 schools, libraries, and universities. It also outlined how to select textbooks and curriculum for U.S. public schools and higher education. In essence, Rutherford attempted to offer a guide or playbook for school committees and leaders who select textbooks and curriculum, and for publishing companies that create those products. As the excerpt on the following page illustrates, Rutherford makes numerous biased statements. She clearly did not want schools to center the genius of Black people.

Rutherford also called for educators to "reject the book that speaks to the slaveholder of the South as cruel and unjust to his slaves," implying that they should spread the message that white slaveholders were kind and loving. She didn't even have the knowledge to call African people by loving and truthful names, for the ancestors were not "slaves." They were doctors, teachers, humanitarians, and thought leaders. At this time, the UDC centered the education of women and girls foremost because women were children's first teachers, and members wanted women to raise their children—and for girls to one day raise their

children—with indoctrinated beliefs that enslavement was positive. They also taught this hate and falsehood to women first because there weren't many male teachers during the time, and the women would in turn teach this to their students. Also, the UDC taught such false things about oppressors because they did not wish for their children to think negatively of their fathers, grandfathers, and great-grandfathers. Rather than use moments to teach their children about anti-racism and abolition, they instead chose to conceal and shield the truth from them. It was Rutherford's mission to erase historical truths and to make enslavement a positive experience in curriculum. She did not want children to feel, what researchers later named, *white guilt*.

I think about parents today who fear their children will feel guilty for the oppression and crimes afflicted by people who look like them from the past. Guilt is an interesting construct in society. Currently in many states, there are initiatives for teachers to avoid making white children feel *guilty* for the actions of white oppressors, past and present. I have never encountered a historically responsive teacher who has made children feel guilty for something they didn't do. *Do folks in society have affinity and connections to slaveholders and others who inflict harm, when they could have chosen love?* If so, maybe that is why they still work to create laws today—to enforce this continued hate for Black people and erasure of truth.

WARNING*†

Do not reject a text-book because it does not contain all that the South claims—a text-book cannot be a complete encyclopedia.

Do not reject a text book because it omits to mention your father, your grandfather, your personal friend, socially or politically—it would take volumes to contain all of the South's great men and their deeds.

Do not reject a text-book because it may disagree with your estimate of the South's great men, and the leaders of the South's Army and Navy—the world can never agree with any one person's estimate in all things.

But—reject a book that speaks of the Constitution other than a Compact between Sovereign States.

Reject a text-book that does not give the principles for which the South fought in 1861, and does not clearly outline the interferences with the rights guaranteed to the South by the Constitution, and which caused secession.

Reject a book that calls the Confederate soldier a traitor or rebel, and the war a rebellion.

Reject a book that says the South fought to hold her slaves.

Reject a book that speaks of the slaveholder of the South as cruel and unjust to his slaves.

Reject a text-book that glorifies Abraham Lincoln and villifies Jefferson Davis, unless a truthful cause can be found for such glorification and villification before 1865.

Reject a text-book that omits to tell of the South's heroes and their deeds when the North's heroes and their deeds are made prominent.

Refuse to adopt any text-book, or endorse any set of books, upon the promise of changes being made to omit the objectionable features.*

A list of books, condemned or commended by the Veterans, Sons of Veterans, and U. D. C., is being prepared by Miss Rutherford as a guide for Text-Book Committees and Librarians.

This list of course contains only the names of those books which have been submitted for examination. Others will be added and published monthly in "*The Confederate Veteran*," Nashville, Tennessee.

* The endorsement of a series of Historical Novels, "The Real Romance of History," was once given by the Historian-General, U. D. C., upon the promise to change the objectionable statements regarding the War between the States. The endorsement was used but the promise was not kept—her endorsement sold many books containing the falsehoods.

† There was not time to submit this "Warning" to the Veterans or Sons of Veterans, but Miss Rutherford thinks it will meet with their approval.

Excerpt from *A Measuring Rod to Test Text Books, and Reference Books in Schools, Colleges and Libraries*

Audre Lorde (1984) offers some clarity on the matter, while evoking water and the earth:

I have no creative use for guilt, yours or my own. Guilt is only another way of avoiding informed action, of buying time out of the pressing need to make clear choices, out of the approaching storm that can feed the earth as well as bend the trees (p. 121).

If any human inflicts harm, that human should feel guilty. That is a healthy emotional response. It is those who feel nothing who we should worry about. It is problematic and incorrect to believe that oppressors of the past did no harm, and that our children should not learn the truth behind oppressors' action—to think, *My children might see themselves in oppressors, and I don't want them to feel guilty*. This mentality does not advance humanity nor show any care for Black and Brown children. We should be asking, Why would children see themselves in racists or anyone who has harmed others? What are we avoiding here? According to Audre Lorde, we are avoiding justice-oriented actions. We are avoiding the earth's needed water.

Yet, we know *A Measuring Rod* was an example of how falsehood is indoctrinated in schools and communities. Rutherford's mission was largely successful. The textbooks that followed taught false and distorted depictions of American history and Black history (Loewen, 2014). What is unique also about *A Measuring Rod* is the absence of student voice. We do not hear children's views of lies and injustice. We do not hear their critiques of "slaveholders." We don't see the guide for white children to identify as abolitionists. We see only an agenda designed to harm children of color. And still, no one thought, *How would such an agenda for curriculum make children feel and love—or to be in the world?*

This erasure and denial of truth in history does not help children become conscious, empathic beings. Rather, the opposite can happen—students may not develop critical literacies that are necessary to question, challenge, and ultimately resist such fabrication. Without critical literacies, students may become passive producers and consumers of knowledge. And that can be dangerous, as children grow older and select friends and partners, make purchases, make medical decisions, and choose candidates to vote for. They may accept anything as truth so that even oppression feels like equity.

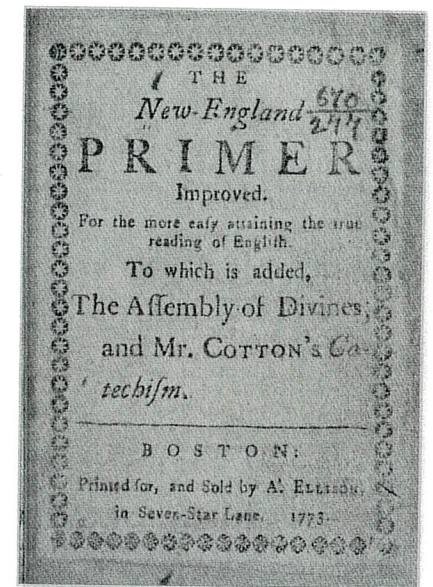
History has shown repeated examples of oppressors working to make injustice, violence, and inequities acceptable and appear like good things. Texts such as *A Measuring Rod* do not allow students to experience joy because students are continually lied to through pedagogy. Students need to see themselves in pedagogy

and be told the truth to be joyful. In *A Measuring Rod*, Rutherford not only neglected to show the genius of Black people (1920), she called for textbooks to depict Black people as joyful only when enslaved. In another publication, she states, "The servants were very happy in their life upon the old plantations" (quoted in Case, 2002, p. 611). Here, for all intents and purposes, she glorifies concentration camps and connects benefits and even happiness to them. If the history of a people is steeped in the "happiness" that comes from being enslaved and violently killed, raped, and oppressed, what does it suggest about Blackness and history? How would Black students feel after receiving this kind of instruction? How would other students feel about Black classmates?

Teaching Black joy means teaching the truth about historical and current events, and especially the truth about the lives of people who have been oppressed in the past. Even when Black folks were fighting oppression through music and art, we had joy in our creativity and collectivism—joy that is largely untaught. The effects of *A Measuring Rod* continue to linger in schools. We still see falsehood and erasure of people of color's humanity today.

The New England Primer

The New England Primer was a children's textbook developed in the 1600s by British journalist Benjamin Harris, who emigrated to Boston, and is my second example of the erasure of genius, joy, and justice. The book followed Harris's earlier textbook, *The Protestant Tutor: Instructing Children to Spel and Read English, and Grounding Them in the True Protestant Religion and Discovering the Errors and Deceits of the Papists*. The primer was published widely throughout the United States and Europe, and, in fewer than 100 pages, became the foundation for the teaching and learning of reading and literacy. Primers of the day tended to be short, likely due to the expense of importing paper from England (Barry, 2008). *The New England Primer* was published in response to the Massachusetts law, the Old Deluder Satan Act of 1647, which mandated reading instruction for individuals to learn how to read print text along with the Bible. Learning to read through the Bible was common then for public education. The wording of "ye old deluder, Satan" meant "to keep one away from Satan" and toward the teachings of the Bible (Willis & Harris, 2000). The word *primer* originally referred to a book of prayers, so it likely comes as no



The New England Primer



Excerpt from *The New England Primer*

No child
benefits
from seeing
or learning
about a single
culture.

Compared to the *Hornbook*, *The New England Primer's* content was more religious in nature and addressed sin (Barry, 2008). It was also adapted into *The Indian Primer*, which propagated the same glorification of whiteness and racist, false views of Indigenous people. The *Indian Primer*, which, of course, was not authored by an Indigenous person, was intended to convert Native people to the primer's version of Christianity.

Problems With the Primer

The first enslaved Africans were violently forced to the United States in 1619, about 70 years before *The New England Primer* was published. The primer did not reflect authentic experiences and identities of children of color. We can infer that oppressors' children learned to read using the primer at school and home, and grew up teaching others the way in which they were taught. The problems related to *The New England Primer* are worth exploring today because the book established the foundation for education as we know it. So, next, I lay out the problems related

surprise to see how religion connected to this text. The Old Deluder Satan Act specifically required white communities to provide their children with literacy teachers.

The goal of *The New England Primer* was to teach and normalize white Christian culture. To the left is a page from it. You can probably see, through a Christian-centered lens, that children learned to read using rote memorization and rime schemes. You can also see that there are animals in the text, along with white males.

The primer extended the textual teachings of the *Hornbook*, which followed this sequence of instruction: recognizing letters of the alphabet, then letter sounds, then sound blends or syllables, which led to simple and complex sentences. The *Hornbook* was used by children for several centuries, beginning in the mid-15th century, in Europe and the United States. The *Hornbook* was actually not a book at all, but rather a wooden paddle with lessons engraved

on it along with the alphabet and the Lord's Prayer, and a leather carrying strap.

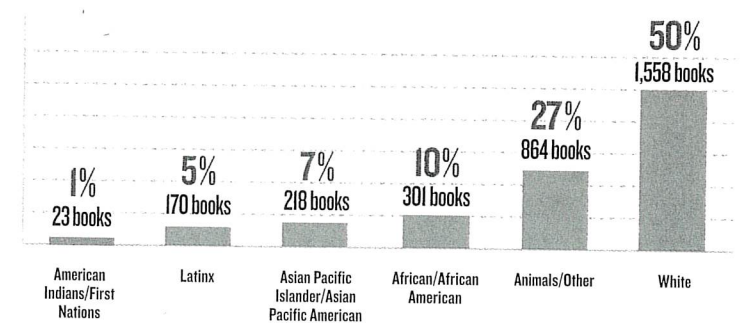
to the primer, whose repercussions we are still dealing with in education today. Consequently, we have a deep need for CRE/CHRE models and practices to advance the achievement of youth moving forward.

Problem 1: The primer was centered on whiteness and white representation, including white characters and culture. It contained no diversity or people of color. It did not contain examples of Black excellence, Black thought, or Black ways of developing literacy. Therefore, it was anti-Black. The same can be said for the excellence and cultural ways of Indigenous people and other people of color. In fact, the text included more representations of animals than people of color. The hegemonic nature of the book prompts the question, *Who was represented and who was not?* It was ahistorical to the histories, identities, and educational needs of people of color. There is a myth that white children benefit when they only see themselves in curriculum. That is false and does a great disservice to white children. No child benefits from seeing or learning about a single culture. Children must see diverse representations of their own lives and of the lives of others, whose race, culture, and/or gender may be different from theirs.

This problem connects to research conducted by the University of Wisconsin-Madison (2019), which proves that there is still a lack of representation in books used in schools. If the curriculum (and books taught within curriculum) is like a mirror, it should reflect wide, varied, and beautiful manifestations of children's lives (Bishop, 1990). Often, educators don't feel the text alone is problematic because it connects to one of many identities of children. When I was a child, I loved *The Baby-Sitters Club* series and other books, in which I saw some of my identities, but certainly not all of them. The mirror must reflect multiculturalism and diverse identities.

Diversity in Children's Books

Percentage of books depicting characters from diverse backgrounds based on publishing statistics compiled by the Cooperative Children's Book Center, School of Education, University of Wisconsin-Madison, based on an inventory of 3,134 books.



Problem 2: The primer was apolitical and lacked criticality and social justice.

It did not acknowledge misrepresentations, racism, sexism, injustices, oppressions, social injuries, or social urgencies of the times. It did not offer opportunities for children to understand race, gender, class, sexuality, religions other than Christianity, or other forms of intersectionality. *Did we need social justice in the 1600s?* Of course we did—just as we need it today. The text was dysconscious and decontextualized with regard to critical problems in society, and, therefore, lacked diversity of thought. Children learning from the primer were not encouraged to think beyond the author's intent. Still today, we see much curriculum for early literacy/early readers with no criticality or examples of social justice.

Problem 3: The primer did not provide opportunities for all children to see themselves or to make sense of their multiple identities. Because of the primer's focus on whiteness, it appeared as if white people were the only people who mattered in society. Also, only two gender identities were represented and there were no opportunities for young people to see themselves, to define themselves, or to make sense of their lives and ideologies.

Problem 4: The primer privileged the English language. Although other languages were spoken during the 1600s, the primer featured only a specific type of English, and it was taught to Indigenous children whose home/cultural language was not English. Despite the fact that there are a growing number of languages spoken in the United States (NCTE, 2020), those languages are still not largely used, nor represented, in curriculum, assessments, state tests, and textbooks.

Problem 5: The primer promoted skills only and did not explicitly offer opportunities for cultivating the pursuits of identity, intellectualism, criticality, and joy. The meaning on each page was solely held within the author's intention and not the individual reader's interpretation. Identity and criticality bring the readers' identities and critical interpretations to the meanings. Furthermore, there were no opportunities to interrogate or debate the text, or respond in writing to it. Skills-only instruction usually involves only textbooks, worksheets, and lectures. We don't see much innovation when curriculum is decontextualized from global lives or identities.

Implications for Education Today

These problems from the early 1600s are still present in structures and mandates of schools today, particularly when it comes to the following five central parts of education:

1. Teaching and Learning Standards and Policies
2. Curriculum and Instruction
3. Assessments and State Tests
4. Teacher and Leader Evaluations
5. Teacher Education Programs

These parts of education impact the outcomes of children and types of children we seek to develop in our schools, but it is possible to still revise them to be more culturally and historically responsive. If we use the power we hold to change any of these parts, we will see a different educational system. We will see joy.

Unearthing Teaching and Learning Standards and Policies

Commonly, state standards are written to address only one-fifth of the culturally and historically responsive model: skills. They do not consider identity, intellect, criticality, and joy. And too often, they lack rigor and excellence. For example, to meet the 2022 Georgia Standards of Excellence (revised last in 2016 to date), kindergartners learn the following social studies skills and content—specifically, according to the standards, “the foundations of the social studies strands.... United States history through the study of important American holidays and symbols.”

Historical Understandings. SSKH1 Identify the national holidays and describe the people and/or events celebrated.

- | | |
|--------------------------------|---|
| a. Christmas | g. New Year's Day |
| b. Columbus Day | h. Presidents Day (George Washington, Abraham Lincoln, and the current president) |
| c. Independence Day | i. Thanksgiving Day |
| d. Labor Day | j. Veterans Day |
| e. Martin Luther King, Jr. Day | |
| f. Memorial Day | |

SSKH2 Identify the following American symbols:

- a. The national and state flags (United States and Georgia flags)
- b. Pledge of Allegiance
- c. Star-Spangled Banner (identify as the national anthem)
- d. The bald eagle
- e. The Statue of Liberty
- f. Lincoln Memorial (identify image and associate with Abraham Lincoln and Presidents Day)
- g. Washington Monument (identify image and associate with George Washington and Presidents Day)
- h. White House (identify image and associate with Presidents Day and the current president)

What do you notice about these standards?

When reading these standards, I thought about what is missing. There is no mention of women, people of color, multiple-language speakers, or white abolitionists. If we are going to teach about those who have inflicted harm on others, we must tell children the truth, or they may grow older needing to unlearn what they've been taught. According to SSKH2, it's more important to teach about the bald eagle than people of color, and how can one teach "foundations" without acknowledging Indigenous people? This list does not suggest "excellence" in learning, as the name of the standards implies.

I argue that we either need a new set of learning standards or a model to teach the existing standards more excellently.

Furthermore, the skills are very low level. To "identify" is not rigorous, even for this grade level—to "identify and critique" would be more rigorous. I argue that we either need a new set of learning standards or a model to teach the existing standards more excellently. A reframed list of standards would develop more than just the skills. It would also develop identity, intellect, criticality, and joy. New standards can be a part of any content or grade level that is more "common" to all children, not just Eurocentric histories. My hope is that we will not see similar standards for learning in years to come.

Until then, below I show how you might teach two of the substandards through a CHRE lens. I have added a family/home connection because we must not teach anything, and students must not learn anything, without our first partners in education: the child's family (however family is defined).

SSKH1 b. Columbus Day

This standard implies Christopher Columbus was a hero and did not inflict harm on others. Therefore, students should be given opportunities to critique the standard, and it should be modified.

Identity: Students will learn about the cultural genius of Indigenous peoples.

Skill: Students will identify, analyze, and critique Columbus Day.

Intellect: Students will learn about Indigenous Peoples' Day and its history.

Criticality: Students will learn about the importance of naming holidays that reflect truth, anti-oppression, and diversity.

Joy: Students will learn ways we can celebrate the beauty of Indigenous peoples and Indigenous Peoples' Day.

Family/Home Connection: As a family, who would we choose to name a holiday after (someone who has made the world or communities better for all)?

SSKH2 c. Star-Spangled Banner (identify as the national anthem)

This standard implies that "The Star-Spangled Banner" is the only national anthem, which is not true. For example, there is the Black national anthem, "Lift Every Voice and Sing," by John Rosamond Johnson and James Weldon Johnson.

Identity: Students will identify songs that give them self-pride.

Skill: Students will identify, analyze and critique "The Star-Spangled Banner."

Intellect: Students will learn about the history of "The Star-Spangled Banner" from the perspectives of people of color in the 19th century.

Criticality: Students will learn about the importance of language written to harm others and why people resisted the full song lyrics.

Joy: Students will learn about the song, "Lift Every Voice and Sing," and the beauty in it.

Family/Home Connection: As a family, make a playlist of songs that lifts our joy.

If the unit were taught according to the standard alone, imagine what children would not learn. In each of these examples, skills connect to something worthwhile in the world. If standards were taught as skills alone, students would miss out on content and opportunities to make connections. By reframing standards according to the five pursuits, as I've done here, we contextualize skills and give students ways to connect them to the real world and their lives. Doing that will not eliminate teaching in deficit or basic ways, but it will shrink the chances. Skills that are not explicitly

Listen to "Lift Every Voice and Sing," Alicia Keys



connected to culture, race, identity, consciousness, or joy could lead to that kind of teaching--teaching that is detached from humanity. We must be watchful of that.

Standards should not be reserved only for students. They should be created for and extended to educators. In addition to the evaluations, educators need a set of standards—or pursuits, as the ancestors affectionately named them. Such pursuits will guide educators and hold them accountable for culturally and historically responsive teaching, learning, and leading. Consider the following pursuits as a start to creating more excellent, more responsible standards for students.

Identity: Teachers and leaders must learn about and show evidence of students' histories, identities, literacies, and liberation. They must authentically respond to students' identities in curriculum, instruction, and leadership practices.

Skills: Teachers and leaders must demonstrate proficient reading, writing, speaking/communication, and content or disciplinary skills, centered in critical love and cultural understandings.

Intellect: Teachers and leaders must exhibit knowledge of multiple cognitive, sociocultural, and critical theories, methods, and scholars/scholarship. They must show proficient or advanced knowledge of what it means to be a scholar of their discipline and profession, and exhibit varied and excellent methods of instruction and leadership.

Criticality: Teachers and leaders must exhibit knowledge and practice of consciousness, and critical thinking, teaching, and leading. They must understand how to name, understand, question, research, and disrupt oppression (hurt, pain, and harm of varied forms in humanity).

Joy: Teachers and leaders must understand how to connect beauty, aesthetics, wellness, wholeness, solutions to problems, and/or happiness to their curricular, instructional, and leadership practices.

When these pursuits are authentically woven into strategic plans (and not merely added as a "component" of those plans), we can then move to adoption of and mandates for policy.

Suggestions for Teaching and Learning Standards and Policies

- Revise state standards to include elements of identity, intellect, criticality, and joy.
- Adopt culturally and historically responsive learning standards for student learning.

- Adopt a model to teach current, unchanged standards in culturally historically responsive ways.
- Adopt culturally and historically responsive teaching and learning standards for teachers and instructional support staff, leaders, and board members.

Unearthing Curriculum and Instruction

Curriculum and instruction today are still mostly, if not only, skills-driven, absent of cultural and historical responsiveness. Curriculum is defined as anything we teach, and the instruction is *how* we teach the curriculum. The "how" we teach curriculum should be detailed in the full package teachers are provided. According to the New York University Metro Center, curriculum includes the "detailed package of learning goals; units and lessons that lay out what teachers teach each day and week; assignments, activities and projects given to students; and books, materials, videos, presentations, and readings used in the class" (2019). With that definition in mind, the curriculum can take the form of a basal reader, a textbook, or a packaged program typically purchased from a publishing company. However, many schools use checklists, syllabi, or a list of standards as their curriculum, which, alone, do not qualify as a full, high-quality curriculum. They serve best as the basis of curriculum to be written. National problems of curriculum include:

- The authors of the curriculum are unclear—including their background in teaching students of color.
- The curriculum lacks equity and culturally responsive education.
- The curriculum has multicultural concepts and some justice-oriented essential questions; yet users consider it fully culturally responsive.
- The curriculum lacks intricate multiculturalism and tokenizes culture.
- The curriculum is grounded in skills only, with no learning objectives or assessments for other pursuits of learning.
- The curriculum is difficult to navigate for teachers and students.
- The curriculum was developed without the input and agreement of young people.
- The curriculum does not reflect the histories, identities, literacies, or liberation of people of color.
- Principals do not understand the curriculum.
- Parents do not understand the curriculum.
- Students do not understand the curriculum.

- The curriculum has not historically responded to the personal and achievement needs of all students.
- The curriculum contains examples of Black or Indigenous history, but it is taught from the perspective of the colonizer.
- The curriculum does not capture the genius and joy of people of color.

Of course, the goal is to embrace humane curriculum and instruction, where students position skills learning in the context of the real world, urgent issues, and diverse people in society. We know that silencing the call for social justice can be dangerous and problematic because it puts children's humanity at stake.

Suggestions for Curriculum and Instruction

- Put out an RFP (request for proposal) to an organization to write a curriculum that you desire for your students.
- Create a rubric or other form of content document that curriculum writers at publishing companies follow, rather than their writing the curriculum without your input.
- Ask publishing companies to conduct random focus groups made up of your districts' children to test the curriculum's effectiveness before purchasing it.
- Consider funding teachers and partners to collaborate on writing or redesigning your school's curriculum.
- Redesign your curriculum according to the five pursuits: skills, identity, intellect, criticality, and joy.
- Organize more diverse content developers that include children, parents, community leaders, scholars, researchers, teachers, noninstructional staff, teachers, school administrators and others who have useful input.

Unearthing Assessments and State Tests

To assess means to gather information to determine how students are experiencing the learning and how well specific pursuits are being enacted in the classroom, school, or district. As educators, we are constantly gathering information from students to examine what we need to do next to inform our instruction or leadership. Yet, traditionally, that information is focused on skills—typically, students' reading and math levels. We rarely, if ever, collect data on identity, intellect, criticality, or joy. State tests have also held bias and lacked CRE/CHRE content, from characters' names in passages to the type of content we deem as important to know. State assessments (a billion-dollar, for-profit industry) center skills only. What if states collected more data along with test skills that they can triangulate with students'

achievement levels? In other words, what if we compared progress within other pursuits to compare with their skill levels? What if we measured and collected data on the things we value? We must show we value more than skills. We must unearth new methods of data collection, research questions, and what we learn of our students. We must also provide state and large-scale assessment in multiple languages. It is sad that, even when English is not a child's first language, that child may still be required to be tested using English-only assessments. In Chapter 4, I offer practical ways to assess the five pursuits.

Suggestions for Assessment

- Create protocols and assessment tools to gather dialogistic, formative, summative, and criterion-referenced data across the five pursuits.
- Create ongoing large-scale assessments for parents, students, teachers, community members, leaders, and board members related to the five pursuits.
- Provide assessments in multiple languages.

Unearthing Teacher and Leader Evaluations

Teacher and leader evaluation is a key piece of the systemic puzzle and a key part of culturally and historically responsive education. If there are teachers or leaders who do not desire identity, skills, intellect, criticality, and joy for students, and don't want to teach and lead in this way (and aren't evaluated in this way), they know they don't *have* to change their practices. We have mandated skills teaching, but not the teaching of identity, intellect, criticality, or joy. We need to ask who wrote our district or city's teacher evaluation. Were they conscious educators who have taught Black and Brown children? Were they people of color? Were Black women on the committee? (Black women have experienced multiple forms of injustice and, therefore, have brilliant perspectives.) I find that in many urban districts, 85–89 percent of children of color adopt evaluations written by white women who never intended those evaluations to be used for culturally responsive education. We need alignment to CHRE standards, curriculum, and assessment. We can no longer afford to keep educators who either inflict explicit or implicit harm or do not keep up with the times. Education must be reserved for the brightest, most genius, and most conscious among us. This is also important for how we recruit and hire new educators.

Suggestions for Evaluation

- Consider what type of teacher or leader is desired and if the evaluation reflects that type.
- Interrogate the evaluation for explicit language around the five pursuits.
- Revise or rewrite evaluation to hold teachers and leaders accountable and responsible for culturally and historically responsive education.

Unearthing Teacher Education

As a professor and teacher educator, almost every day I deep dream about what the next generation of teachers needs to be well and to be successful. School leaders must reserve funding by going to area universities and demanding (to use the language of youth) the types of classes and other forms of professional development that are needed for candidates to be hired in their districts. As we strengthen school-university partnerships, how can we recruit and admit students into teaching programs based on different criteria? When speaking to music and art students, I noticed that many programs require a portfolio or audition. I considered a process to audition the potential genius of students who were called to education so that everyone isn't admitted into a teacher education program and that genius potential teachers are not excluded. I had an experience with a student who was admitted into a teaching program even though that student had written very racist things about Black people in an application essay. That student received top grades (even in a diversity course) and graduated with an education degree. To this day, I don't understand how someone who demeaned a group of people can then go out into the world to teach children who belong to the same group that the teacher demeaned. I wondered, what if we had unique requirements for this student to enter the teacher education program? What if he had to create a portfolio and artistic showcase of ideas that displayed his potential to teach excellence across Black cultures?

We must screen the genius and consciousness of those who will be teachers and give them an education that evaluates their minds, hearts, and responsiveness, and not just their ability to teach content skills. Additionally, we must ensure that teacher candidates are learning from diverse thinkers beyond Vygotsky, Dewey, Piaget, and Maslow. We don't typically see thinkers on the syllabus such as Mary McLeod Bethune, Carter G. Woodson, W. E. B. Du Bois, Anna Julia Cooper, Maria Stewart, Elizabeth Flood, or Clara Muhammad. Programs must not offer just one course in diversity, CRE, or consciousness. Instead, all courses must somehow honor this approach to learning.

Suggestions for Teacher Education

In my deep dreaming, a reframed teacher-education program would have the following courses:

- **Self and Humanity:** a course devoted to discovery and unpacking of self, ideologies, social conditions and thinking, and how our own identities and histories affect teaching for humanity
- **History of BIPOC Literacy Education:** a course devoted to ways BIPOC have engaged in wide literacies to develop education across the disciplines across the globe
- **Theories of Education:** a course devoted to learning of multiple theories and how they help to explain methods, strategies, and current practices in education ✓
- **Becoming Scholars of Disciplines:** a course devoted to learning how to observe the world in mathematics, science, social studies, and English language arts and how to authentically connect skills/standards to the world and needs for humanity
- **CHRE core course and CHRE embedded in methods courses:** a core course devoted to history and practical learning of culturally and historically responsive education and other resource models for learning, followed by subsequent practice of the five pursuits in methods courses
- **Joy, Self-Care, and Wellness:** a course devoted to ways educators can elicit and enact joy and wellness in their own lives, in the classroom, and at school ✓

Dismantling and (Re)building: Searching for Joy in the Gardens

"We are a people. A people do not throw their geniuses away. And if they are thrown away, it is our duty as artists and as witnesses for the future to collect them again for the sake of our children."

—ALICE WALKER, *In Search of Our Mothers' Gardens: Womanist Prose*

When these five parts of the system (standards/policies, curriculum, assessment, evaluation, and teacher education) are (re)built, we will see the potential for joy among children and educators. In this book, I aim to write for the human condition and provide the water (materials and tools) needed to (re)plant systems and the thinking to grow more evolved schools and classrooms—thereby reviving systemic

structures of education. In education, there must be structural change for those inside of and affected by the system. The system and the people within it need (re)planting and the opportunity to grow, using materials and tools that have historically proven to be effective. Those already striving for humanizing practices need supports for sustainability.

If you are like me, you are tired of celebrating “despite students”—students who achieve despite a system that did not nurture or love them. I was a “despite student,” one who did not see a teacher of color in high school or learn about the genius or joy of Black women. Yet, I achieved. I was celebrated. But imagine how children could excel when the system is designed for their full success—where they don’t have to overcome the system or be someone else to thrive. As educators, or waterers, we can help children reach their genius—bloom to their greatness—through culturally and historically responsive pedagogies. In Chapter 2, I unearth curriculum further, providing ways for you to move toward the pursuit of joy, the ultimate goal for education.

Chapter 1 Reflection

Select one or more questions to engage in a freewrite.

- What are some reactions and reflections you have about the music, art, and text from Chapter 1?
- What ideas and passages stand out for you and why?
- What parts do you want to explore and learn about more?
- What parts of the educational system have helped you to grow?
- What parts of the educational system are in need of water?
- What do you plan to do to unearth genius and joy?

Take some time to color this image.

